

Fly Casting Mastery Workshop

1-Day Course · Module One — The Foundational Stroke · Student Handout

STRATEGY

Knowledge · Wisdom · Intent

LINE CONTROL

Pause · Power · Path

TACTICS

Active · Passive · Erratic

Name: _____

Date: _____

THE TWO RULES OF FLY CASTING

Rule 1: What the rod tip does, the line does.

Rule 2: Don't forget Rule 1.

Resources: [Leader Construction](#) · [Fly Casting Terms & Definitions](#) · [Fly Fishing Terms & Definitions](#)

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1 Why We Need a Foundational Stroke

20 min

CUE *Poor practice doesn't just stall you — it wires the wrong movement into your muscle memory.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **Two Rules of Fly Casting:** Rule 1 — what the rod tip does, the line does. Rule 2 — don't forget Rule 1
- **Casting originated ~1850:** Samuel Phillipe's 6-strip cane rod, braided silk lines, and fixed guides made shooting line possible
- Direct feedback from a coach is irreplaceable — books and video lack real-time correction that wires correct movement into muscle memory
- Poor practice sessions don't just stall progress — they actively encode faults via myelin (Daniel Coyle, The Talent Code)
- **The Fly Fisher's Triad:** Strategy + Line Control (Pause/Power/Path) + Tactics — the organizing map of the whole course
- The vertical casting plane is derived from tournament casters — four decades of proof that it works for everyone

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- None — concept introduction only
- **Q&A:** surface and correct misconceptions before any rod touches a hand
- **Two Rules quiz:** instructor calls a fault, student names which Rule was broken

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can state both Rules without looking
- ☐ I understand why structured practice matters more than time on the water

2 Pause, Power & Path — The Three Components

25 min

CUE *Back off and think smooth. Most students use too much power, too early.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **Pause / Power / Path:** the three components of every cast, every mend, every on-stream presentation — the Fly Fisher's Triad of line control
- A.L.E. (Jason Borger): A = Acceleration (smooth start, tip travels as straight as possible) → L = Loop Formation (the flick out of the line plane) → E = Energy Transfer (dead-still stop)
- **Pause:** timing — the period after the backcast that allows the line to straighten. Creep is a fault; Drift corrects it
- **Power:** rate of movement — negative, constant, and positive acceleration all produce different rod loads and loop outcomes
- **Path:** what the rod tip does, the line does (Rule 1). Straight tip path = tight loop. Concave path = tailing loop
- One fault in any component cascades immediately into the other two — they are inseparable

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- **Tug-of-war feel drill:** student holds leader end, instructor holds fly line — student feels tension before touching a rod
- A.L.E. pantomime (Mel Krieger, 1975): perform the casting motion without a rod — develop muscle memory before adding rod and line
- **Fault cascade drill:** instructor changes only the pause — students observe how power and path are immediately affected

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can describe all three phases of A.L.E.
- ☐ I know what Creep is and how Drift fixes it
- ☐ I can identify which component broke when my cast goes wrong

Why Efficient Movement Matters — Step 1 Continued

CUE *Efficient movement eliminates 85% of frustrations in the beginning — get it right early, and you won't spend years unlearning it.*

WHAT WE COVER

- Efficient movement is the foundation everything else is built on — developing it early can eliminate 85% of the frustrations and mistakes that would otherwise need correcting later.
- **The Talent Code (Daniel Coyle):** movement is learned through myelin — every repetition, correct or incorrect, wires that pattern into the body.
- When re-learning efficient movement, start with smaller tasks — isolate one piece of the motion. More reps on a small task build the memory faster than reps on the whole movement.
- Position & Power = Performance (Nick Winkleman, The Language of Coaching): find out if the caster can get into the correct position before refining anything else — position determines the power available.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- **Position check:** without a rod, each student gets into ready position — instructor verifies before any casting begins.
- **Rigged-and-ready commitment:** each student names where they'll keep a rod and line rigged (garage, by the door) for short practice between sessions.
- **Small-task isolation:** pick one piece of the stroke and repeat it slowly on its own before linking it back into the full motion.

SELF-CHECK

- ☐ I understand why efficient movement matters before speed
- ☐ I have a plan for short, rigged-and-ready practice

3 The Three-Point Grip & Casting Methods

20 min

CUE *Grip is the final link in the kinetic chain — it starts at your feet, not your hand.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **Three casting methods:** Wrist Only → Forearm → Whole Arm (most advanced — widest range of control)
- Whole Arm Casting evolved from tournament casting. Walter Mansfield cast 133 feet in 1899 — world record for 35 years
- **Three-Point Grip:** index finger up on the handle. Used by George Selwyn Marriott ("Prince of Fly Fishers") — hit a 1-inch target at 20 yards

- Three-Point allows the wrist to fully participate AND enables more precise rod pointing
- **Thumb-on-Top:** power and distance. V-Grip: finesse and soft delivery
- **Grip pressure:** the handshake principle — firm enough to control, loose enough to feel the rod flex

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- **Grip pantomime:** form Three-Point Grip without a rod, eyes closed, 5 repetitions — build proprioception
- **Pencil-tip drill:** tape a pencil to the rod tip — observe how 1 cm of wrist deviation moves the tip dramatically
- **Method comparison:** cast 5 times wrist-only, 5 forearm, 5 whole arm — student observes and describes loop difference

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can form the Three-Point Grip without looking at my hand
- ☐ I understand why Whole Arm is the foundation for everything advanced

4 Whole Arm Casting — The Overhead Cast

30 min

CUE *Arm lift and wrist flick end at the same time — NEVER arm first, then wrist.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **The 'C' Pickup:** flip the rod tip in a C to tension the line before casting — never cast a slack line
- **Backcast:** forearm parallel to ground, rod accelerates back and up. Hand rises to face-height, outside the shoulder
- **Mac's Pipe:** in the L phase, the rod tip is flicked out of the line plane. Swift movement — abrupt stop
- The casting arc is variable — there is no single fixed stop point. For a first backcast carrying 30–50 ft of line, stop close to vertical so the backcast climbs above horizontal on the pickup. That's all that's needed, because the next stroke is the delivery
- **Drift during the pause:** rod drifts back and up a few inches — extends the forward stroke
- **Forward cast:** karate-chop motion. Arc length and stop point adjust with how much line is out and the loop size you want — more line or a wider loop opens the arc; less line or a tighter loop closes it
- False casting repeatedly is a poor choice when fishing — work toward delivering the fly on the pickup or the very next stroke
- **The Casting Chart:** hang at elbow height (base line = forearm length). Move hand along stroke line — most reliable tool for training straight tip path

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- **Casting Chart:** hang at elbow height, student moves hand along stroke line 20 repetitions before picking up a rod
- **Mac's Pipe drill:** develop the flick — abrupt stop must be sharp and crisp before adding to the full cast
- **Stop-and-hold backcast:** cast backward with 30–50 ft of line, hold the rod near vertical for 3 seconds — instructor verifies the backcast climbs above horizontal
- **Mirror drill:** cast facing a full-length mirror — identify which body segments move on each cast

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ My backcast consistently climbs above horizontal, whatever arc length gets me there
- ☐ Arm lift and wrist flick end simultaneously
- ☐ I am using the whole arm — shoulder, elbow, forearm, wrist

5 The Casting Triangle & Loop Analysis

15 min

CUE *Every loop shape is a direct readout of what the rod tip did. Rule 1 is always at work.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **Rod Leg:** from rod tip to the nose of the loop. Fly Leg: from fly to the nose. Both must be in the same plane
- Loop size = how far the rod tip is flicked out of the line plane (the L phase). ONLY the flick controls loop size
- **Tailing Loop:** caused by a concave rod tip path (pushing instead of karate-chopping). Causes wind knots and lost distance
- **Wide Power Loop:** butt-flexed cast — fast, high-energy, used for distance
- **V-Loop:** rod tip describes a V (Thrust Cast) — cuts into wind
- Tight triangle = efficient energy. Wide/collapsed triangle = wasted energy

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- **Slow-motion film with tip path tracing:** draw the path on screen, student names the loop type and its cause
- **Prediction drill:** instructor describes a tip path in words — student draws the resulting loop before casting
- **Five-clip diagnosis:** five unlabeled clips — student ranks tightest to widest and explains the tip path behind each

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can name the rod leg and fly leg in my loop
- ☐ I know what caused a tailing loop (and which Rule it violates)
- ☐ I can produce a tight and a wide loop intentionally

6 The Backcast — Trajectory & the 180 Rule**25 min**

CUE *The backcast must climb above horizontal — like an airplane on takeoff, not leveling off on the runway.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **The 180 Rule:** backcast must be exactly opposite the target — when honored, every segment of line moves as one unit (synergy)
- **Trajectory:** the backcast climbs above horizontal — the airplane-on-takeoff angle means the line is perfectly positioned when the pause ends
- **Drift (not Creep):** drift the rod back and up a few inches during the pause — extends stroke length without losing the stop point
- Pause length scales with line length — more line in the air requires more pause time
- **Sidearm Casting:** tip the rod to the side — keeps line lower, less visible to fish, less wind exposure, under obstacles
- Shooting on the backcast is possible sidearm — turn and point the rod down the line, use the 'O' Ring for line control

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- **Stop-and-look drill:** cast, stop, turn — watch the line fully lay out and diagnose trajectory
- **Wall drill:** 3 feet from a wall — physical, immediate consequence for a level or downward backcast
- **Partner call drill:** partner calls 'now' when line fully unrolls — internalizes pause timing from outside the caster
- **Obstacle simulation:** set physical obstacles to simulate bank vegetation — student adapts backcast angle and plane

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ My backcast consistently climbs above horizontal
- ☐ I understand the 180 Rule and why violating it costs me distance and accuracy
- ☐ I can adjust my backcast angle for a tight space

7 The Forward Cast — Integration & Synergy

25 min

CUE *Feel the rod load before starting forward. Don't chase the line — wait for it.*

WHAT WE COVER

- The forward cast is the payoff of everything before it — faults here trace directly back via Rule 1
- **Timing:** begin the forward cast before the line falls — feel the rod load during the A phase
- **Karate-chop forward stroke:** smooth acceleration to the flick (L) and a dead-still stop (E). The stop transfers all energy
- **The 'O' Ring:** line hand forms an O-ring around the line while shooting — full line control at all times. Essential for fishing
- **Lift and Point after shooting:** lift rod and point it down the rod leg — reduces guide friction and adds distance
- **Synergy (Aristotle):** the integrated cast takes many practice sessions to feel connected. Explicitly normalize this.

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- **Target drill:** hula hoop at 30 ft — 5 of 6 before advancing
- **Distance ladder:** 20 → 25 → 30 → 35 ft — only advance when loop stays tight and 'O' Ring is used
- **10-cast self-evaluation:** score each cast Pause/Power/Path (1–3), identify the dominant pattern, write in journal
- **Integration flow:** 15 minutes of uninterrupted casting — instructor observes only, no corrections

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I am using the O Ring on every shoot
- ☐ I can feel the line load before starting the forward cast
- ☐ I can self-score my cast on Pause, Power, and Path separately

8 Trajectory Control, Loop Management & Wind

45 min

CUE *The Double Haul triples line speed. Less time in the air = less time for wind to cause trouble.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **Wind from Line Hand Side:** haul + Kentucky Windage (aim off-target) + keep line as low as possible

- **Wind from Casting Arm Side:** Across the Head Casting is the real solution — not sidearm alone
- **Wind from Behind:** Elliptical Stroke — cast low on backstroke (haul hard), come up high on forward stroke
- **Wind into the Face:** Squat Cast + haul + cast the line ON the surface of the water
- **Elliptical Stroke (Gebetsroither, Austria, 1930s):** backcast sidearm, forward stroke more upright — rod describes an ellipse
- **Thrust Cast:** during the L phase, flick the tip AND thrust the rod toward the target simultaneously — creates a V-Loop

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Four-direction wind carousel — apply correct strategy for each direction
- Elliptical Stroke pantomime — verify the ellipse path
- Thrust Cast pantomime — flick and thrust must be simultaneous

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I know the correct response for all four wind directions
- ☐ I can execute the Elliptical Stroke to turn over a weighted fly
- ☐ I understand what creates a V-Loop and when to use it

9 The Double Haul & Shooting for Distance

40 min

CUE 'Haul Late' — say it out loud every repetition until the timing is automatic.

WHAT WE COVER

- **The Double Haul:** pull sharply on the line with the line hand during the L phase — increases line speed to ~3x
- **Historical:** Marvin Hedge introduced it in 1934 — immediately broke Walter Mansfield's 35-year world distance record
- The haul MUST come during L (Loop Formation) — not before, not after. Mantra: 'Haul Late'
- **Learning sequence:** Single Haul on backcast → immediately return line hand → Single Haul on forward cast → combine
- **Triple Haul:** third haul after E — immediately turns over a reluctant leader; delayed 1–2 sec creates S-Curves for drag-free drift

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Haul-only drill — practice the line-hand motion without casting
- Clap drill — instructor claps at the correct L moment; you haul at the clap
- Comparison shoot — measure distance with and without Double Haul

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can execute a Single Haul on the backcast with correct timing
- ☐ My line hand returns immediately after every haul
- ☐ I understand what the Triple Haul does and when to use it

10 Presentation Casting, Mending & Practice Design**30 min**

CUE *In-the-air mending is always better than on-water mending — it doesn't disturb the fly.*

WHAT WE COVER

- **Mending:** changing the position of the line after the cast — on water or in the air before it lands
- **Reach Mend:** cast to target, then reach the rod tip to the side while line is flowing — line drops on the hypotenuse of a triangle. Say 'Cast/Reach' out loud
- **Curve Mend:** reach to the side then back again — places a curve in the line
- **Puddle Mend:** aim above horizontal, drop rod immediately after E — creates controlled slack
- **Parachute Mend:** cast horizontally, pull rod to vertical after E — line parachutes down. For downstream presentations
- **Practice design:** 80% focused repetition of known skills, 20% exploration

DRILLS FOR THIS STEP

- Reach Mend to 12-inch ring target — 4 of 6 hits
- Mend type carousel — Reach, Curve, Puddle, Parachute on command
- Write your 4-week personal practice plan in session

SELF-CHECK BEFORE MOVING ON

- ☐ I can execute a Reach Mend and understand what problem it solves on stream
- ☐ I have a written practice plan with specific goals
- ☐ I know my top 2 recurring faults and their corrections

My Personal Fault Library

Use this page after the session. Identify your top recurring faults and write the correction in your own words.

FAULT #1**What it looks / feels like**

Which component broke: Pause / Power / Path · A.L.E. phase: A / L / E (circle one)

My specific correction

FAULT #2

What it looks / feels like

Which component broke: Pause / Power / Path · A.L.E. phase: A / L / E (circle one)

My specific correction

FAULT #3

What it looks / feels like

Which component broke: Pause / Power / Path · A.L.E. phase: A / L / E (circle one)

My specific correction

Quick Reference Card

The Two Rules

Rule 1: What the rod tip does, the line does. · Rule 2: Don't forget Rule 1.

A.L.E.

A: Acceleration — smooth start, straight path · L: Loop Formation — the flick out of the plane · E: Energy Transfer — dead-still stop

Pause / Power / Path	Pause: let the line unroll before the forward cast · Power: smooth, then accelerate · Path: straight tip path = tight loop
Common faults	Tailing loop: concave tip path — karate-chop, don't push · Wind knot: almost always a tailing loop (Rule 1) · Crash landing: trajectory too low
The Fly Fisher's Triad	Strategy (knowledge, wisdom, intent) + Line Control (pause, power, path) + Tactics (active, passive, erratic)
Practice tip	80% focused repetition of skills you know. 20% exploration of new ones. Short, correct sessions beat long, sloppy ones.